

MIDDLE PALISADE

14,040 ft · East Face (Class 3) · Standard Route

Route guide for a day climb on **Saturday, October 3, 2026** from Glacier Lodge (Big Pine, CA). Built from a dozen trip reports, the 1921 first-ascent route, USGS 1 m lidar and 30 cm aerial imagery, and the NWS forecast issued Oct 2.



Middle Palisade and the Middle Palisade Glacier from the northeast, on the approach from Finger Lake (June 18, 2020, with far more snow than you will see in October). Photo: Penitentes / Hike395, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons.

Summit	14,040 ft (4,279 m)
Distance	~6 mi one way, ~12-13 mi round trip
Gain	~6,500 ft (trailhead 7,790 ft)
Difficulty	Class 3, a few 3+/4 moves, loose rock, big exposure
Time	11-15 hr car-to-car for most day parties
Key hazards	Rockfall, route-finding, late-season ice, darkness

Lines on maps are approximate: the trail comes from OpenStreetMap, and the cross-country and face lines were placed by hand from USGS imagery and lidar plus trip-report descriptions. Navigate by the terrain and the written description. Climbing is dangerous, and you are responsible for your own decisions.

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Using this on your phone

Save this PDF to Files / Google Drive **offline** before you lose signal. Pinch-zoom the maps: they are high resolution.

A companion **GPX file** ([middle_palisade_route.gpx](#)) has the track and all waypoints. Import it into Gaia GPS, CalTopo, onX, or similar, and download the offline map layers tonight.

Put your phone in airplane mode to save battery. GPS still works. Carry a battery pack.

Waypoint letters are the same on every map: **P X B F T M R G C N S** (trailhead to summit).

The route in 60 seconds

Trail 4.3 mi from Glacier Lodge up the South Fork of Big Pine Creek to **Brainerd Lake** (10,240 ft).

Use trail up the slope W of Brainerd to **Finger Lake**. Cross its outlet, go S along the W side, then up to a **tarn** (11,190 ft).

Moraine: follow the rocky moraine that splits the Middle Palisade Glacier into two lobes to its head at the face (12,700 ft).

Face: in October use the **red-rock start**, the loose red/white gully just right (N) of the moraine head. It joins the **main chute**. Climb ~1,000–1,300 ft of class 3, staying in the chute and trending **left** when unsure.

Top: two notches above; aim for the **LEFT** one. About 50 ft below it, traverse **left (south)** to the summit blocks and finish from the south side.

Down: reverse it exactly. **Turn around by 1:00 PM** wherever you are.

1. Tomorrow at a glance: Sat Oct 3, 2026

Weather: NWS point forecasts (api.weather.gov, grid VEF, issued Oct 2, 2026 06:33 UTC):

	Day (Sat)	Night (Sat)	Wind
Summit 14,000 ft	Sunny, high ~47°F, falling to ~44°F in the afternoon	Low ~36°F	ENE 5–13 mph, gusts to 20
Finger Lake ~11,900 ft*	Sunny, high ~55°F	Low ~41°F	ENE 3–14 mph, gusts to 21
Trailhead ~7,300 ft*	Sunny, high ~74°F	Low ~56°F	ESE 1–16 mph
Tonight (Fri)	Mostly cloudy: summit low ~37°F, Finger Lake ~42°F		

*Grid-cell average elevations. Recheck the forecast before you leave: forecast.weather.gov, search "Middle Palisade" or use lat/lon 37.0706, -118.4694. Wind chill on the summit will feel like the mid-30s °F.

Daylight (Big Pine Creek, PDT): civil dawn ~6:24 AM · **sunrise ~6:50 AM · sunset ~6:34 PM** · dark ~7:00 PM. The canyon walls cut direct sun earlier. The East Face gets morning sun and goes into shade in the afternoon, which means colder rock and colder fingers on the descent. Moon: waning, about half full, rising around midnight, so you get some moonlight on a pre-dawn start.

Suggested day-trip schedule (moderate pace; adjust to yours):

Time	Where	Notes
4:30 AM	Leave trailhead (P)	Headlamps. Fill water at the creek later.
~5:15	Creek crossing (X), mile 1.5	Low water in Oct: rock-hop
~7:00	Brainerd Lake (B), mile 4.3	End of maintained trail
~7:45	Finger Lake outlet (F)	Cross to the W side
~8:30	Tarn (T), 11,190 ft	Fill up: last easy water
~10:00	Moraine head (M), 12,700 ft	Helmets on, stash poles
~12:30 PM	Summit (S)	Sign the register
1:00 PM	HARD TURNAROUND	Wherever you are
~3:30	Back at moraine head	Downclimbing is slow
~5:00	Finger Lake	Sunset 6:34
~6:15	Brainerd Lake	Headlamps from here
~8:30 PM	Trailhead	~16 hr. Faster parties: 11–13 hr

Decisions to make before you go

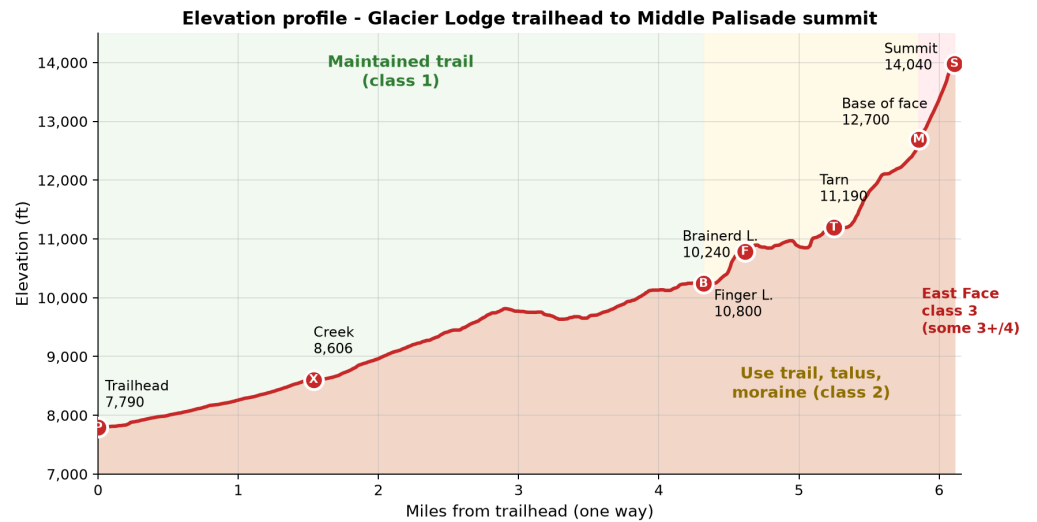
- 1. Start:** use the **red-rock start** (no glacier travel). In October both glacier lobes are usually bare, hard ice with a deep moat at the top.
- 2. Crampons/axe:** needed only if you plan the classic glacier start. Microspikes are a light hedge against frozen patches.
- 3. Turnaround:** 1:00 PM, or earlier if you are not at the base of the face by ~10:30.
- 4. Bail triggers:** fresh snow or ice in the chute, building clouds, a party knocking rocks down from above, or anyone unwell.

2. Overview map



USGS topo with the full route. Solid = trail; dashed = cross-country. Circled numbers are miles from the trailhead. Pinch-zoom for detail.

Elevation profile



Profile computed from USGS 3DEP elevation data along the route line. The small ups and downs near mile 5 are the contour along the west side of Finger Lake.

GPS waypoints (WGS84, decimal degrees)

	Waypoint	Lat, Lon	Elev ft	Mile
P	Day-use parking / trailhead (road end, Glacier Lodge)	37.12524, -118.43761	7,790	0.0
X	South Fork creek crossing (ford/rock-hop)	37.10981, -118.44960	~8,600	1.5
B	Brainerd Lake - end of maintained trail	37.09173, -118.45741	10,240	4.3
F	Finger Lake outlet - cross on rocks to west side	37.08880, -118.46130	10,800	4.6
T	Tarn above Finger Lake (camps, last easy water)	37.08030, -118.46105	11,190	5.2
M	Head of medial moraine - base of East Face	37.07310, -118.46695	12,700	5.9
R	Red-rock band (late-season start)	37.07325, -118.46730	~12,800	5.9
G	Gendarme / variations merge (approx.)	37.07255, -118.46806	~13,110	5.9
C	Main chute, mid-face (approx.)	37.07152, -118.46852	~13,510	6.0
N	Near top: bear LEFT (S) below the notch (approx.)	37.07100, -118.46915	~13,840	6.1
S	Middle Palisade summit 14,040 ft	37.07055, -118.46939	14,040	6.1

P, X and B are on the mapped trail. F through M follow the use trail and moraine and are good to ±30 m. R, G, C and N on the face are approximate (±20–40 m), located from lidar and trip-report beta. Summit: lidar high point 14,036 ft; published 14,040 ft (older maps say 14,012 or 14,018).

3. Drive, parking & permits



The Eastern Sierra above Bishop and Big Pine. Photo: Tom Hilton, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons.

Getting there

- In **Big Pine** on US-395, turn west on **Crocker Ave**, which becomes **Glacier Lodge Road**. Drive about 10 miles up Big Pine Creek canyon to the end of the road at Glacier Lodge (~7,800 ft). Last gas and food are in Big Pine.
- **Day-use parking** is at the road end by the old Glacier Lodge (waypoint **P**). It is small; arrive early.
- **Overnight parking** is the large backpacker lot ~0.6 mi before the road end ("Big Pine Creek trailhead"). If you are camping, park there and walk up the road to the day-use area.

Permits & rules

- **Day climb: no wilderness permit needed.** In the Inyo NF only the Mt. Whitney zone requires a day-use permit.
- **Overnight** (e.g. camping at Finger Lake or the tarn): you need an Inyo NF wilderness permit for the **Big Pine Creek South Fork** trailhead. Trailhead quotas apply May 1 to Nov 1. Reserve or check walk-up availability on Recreation.gov. Wilderness permit office: (760) 873-2483. White Mountain Ranger Station, 798 N. Main St., Bishop: (760) 873-2500.
- Ask about food-storage (bear canister) rules for the area when you get the permit. Pack out all trash and TP. No campfires above the lakes.

Tell someone

Leave your plan with someone at home: route, party, car, **expected return (~9 PM)**, and when to call Inyo County Sheriff (760) 878-0383 if you have not checked in (suggest midnight).

4. Trail: Glacier Lodge to Brainerd Lake

P to B · 4.3 mi · 7,790 to 10,240 ft · maintained trail (class 1) · 2-2.5 hr

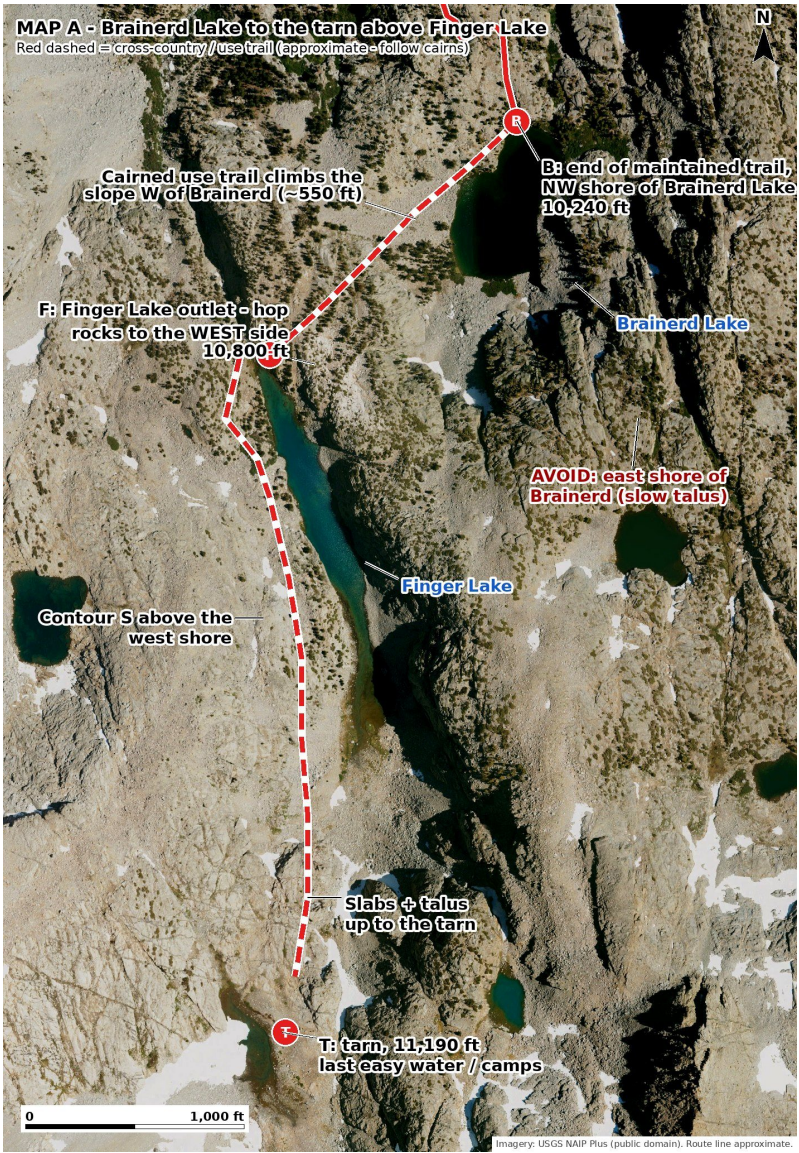
- **0.0-0.3 mi:** From the day-use lot walk west along the continuation of the road/trail, cross a footbridge, and follow signs for the **South Fork Big Pine Creek** trail toward **Brainerd Lake / Willow Lake**. The trail heads **south** up the South Fork canyon. Do **not** take the North Fork trail toward Big Pine Lakes / Palisade Glacier.
- **0.3-1.5 mi:** Gentle climbing through sagebrush and desert scrub; aspens along the creek have fall color in early October.
- **~1.5 mi (8,600 ft) · X: creek crossing** (marked as a ford on OpenStreetMap). Early-summer reports describe wading or hunting for logs; in October flow is low and it is usually a rock-hop. If it looks bad, scout ~100 yards upstream. In the dark, make sure you pick the trail back up on the far side.
- **1.6-2.9 mi:** The trail climbs **long switchbacks up a granite headwall** (~1,200 ft) out of the brush. The longest sustained climb on the trail.
- **2.9-3.4 mi:** Top out and drop slightly into the marshy basin by **Willow Lake** (~9,650 ft, off to the right/west). Stay on the main trail toward Brainerd Lake.
- **3.4-4.3 mi:** More switchbacks up to **Brainerd Lake** (10,240 ft). The maintained trail ends at the lake's **north/northwest shore (B)**. Middle Palisade and Norman Clyde Peak are in view ahead. Good spot to filter water.

Navigation note

The trail is easy to follow, even by headlamp. The darkness risk is on the way **down**: the cross-country section above Brainerd is much harder to follow at night. Aim to be back at Brainerd Lake by dusk (~6:30 PM).

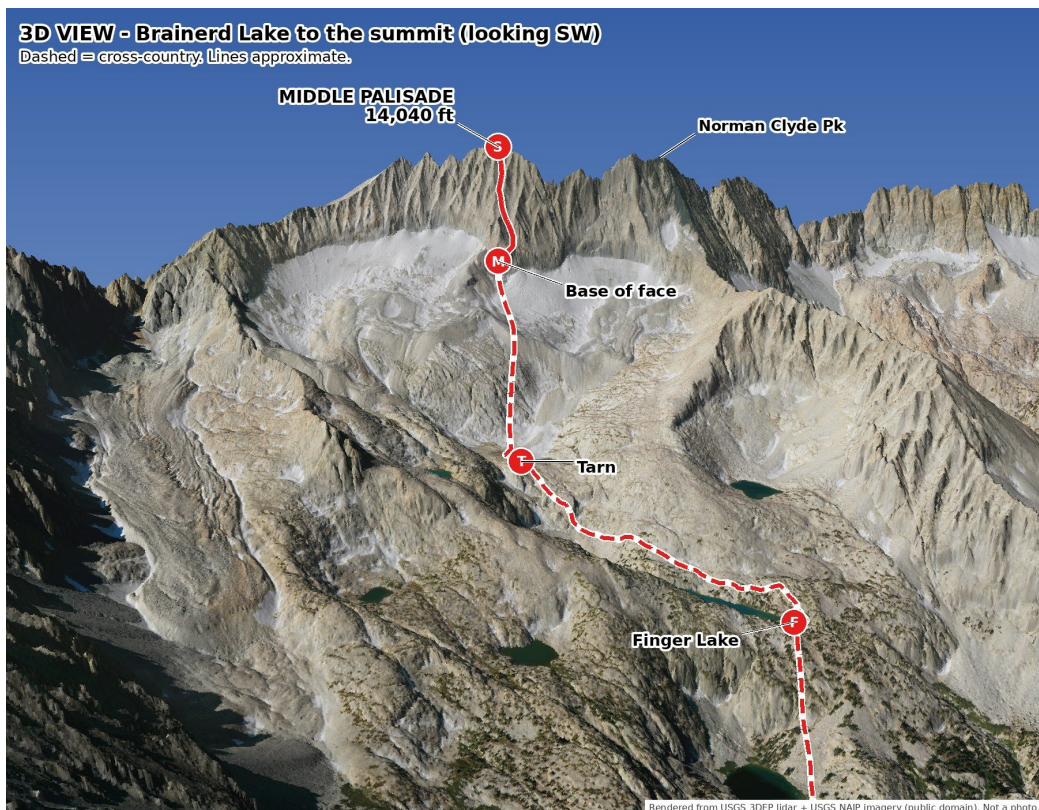
5. Brainerd Lake to Finger Lake to the tarn

B to F to T · ~0.9 mi · 10,240 to 11,190 ft · use trail, slabs, talus (class 2) · 1-1.5 hr



Map A: USGS NAIP aerial imagery (public domain) with the approximate line. North is up.

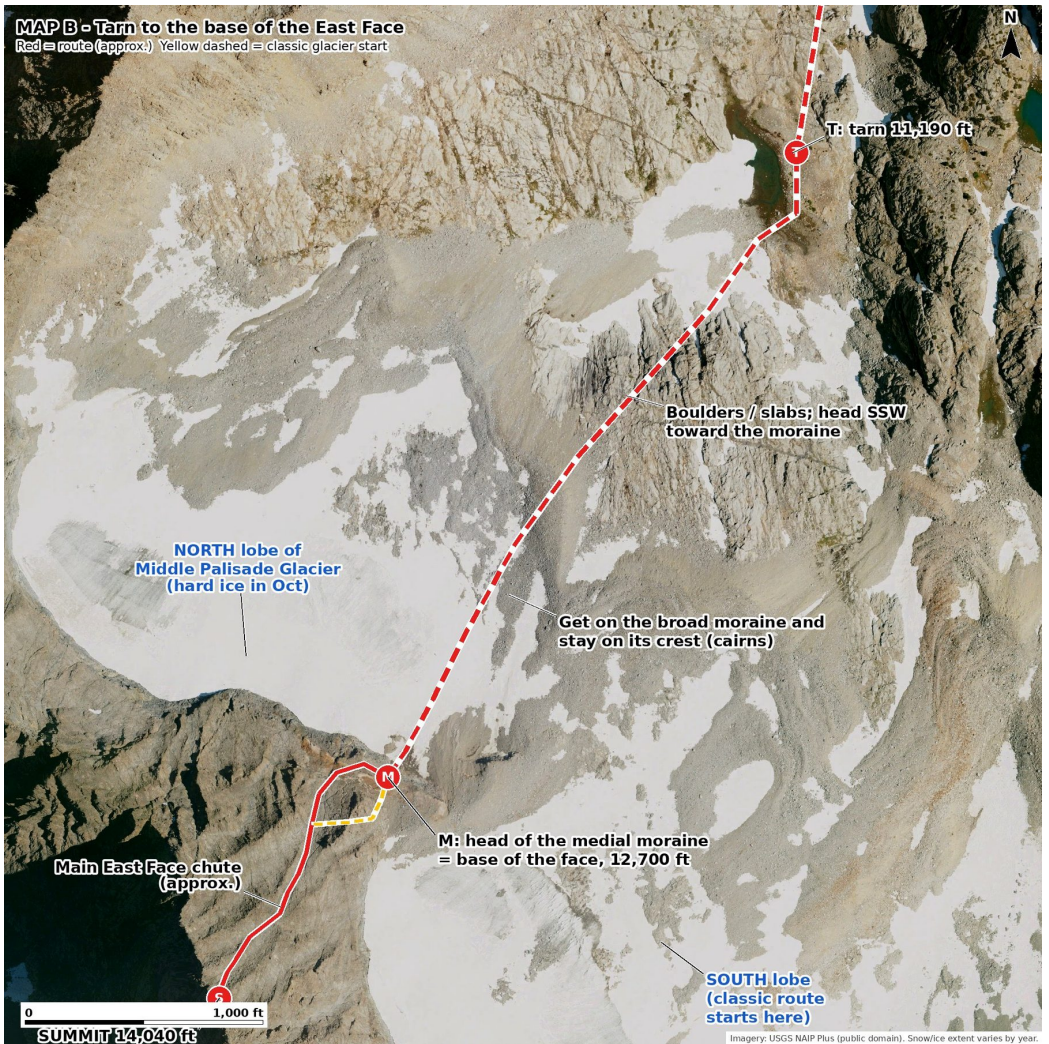
- At Brainerd's north/northwest shore (B), look for a **cairned use trail** heading up the slope **west of Brainerd Lake** (to your right as you face the lake). It climbs ~550 ft southwest through trees, slabs and boulders.
- **Avoid the east shore of Brainerd.** Several reports call that line slow and miserable talus.
- You reach the north tip of **Finger Lake** (10,800 ft), a long, narrow, turquoise lake in a slot. **F**: hop across the **outlet on rocks** to the **west side**.
- Climb ~100 ft up the slope west of the lake and **contour south** above the west shore. This avoids the cliffy waterline.
- From the south end of the lake continue **S/SSW up slabs and talus** to a small **tarn at ~11,190 ft (T)**, a popular camp.
- **Fill all your water here.** Above this point water is unreliable in October; meltwater may be frozen in the morning.



3D view rendered from USGS lidar + aerial imagery (not a photo), looking SW from above Brainerd Lake. Finger Lake to the tarn to the moraine to the face. Lines approximate.

6. Tarn to the base of the East Face

T to M · ~0.65 mi · 11,190 to 12,700 ft · boulders, moraine (class 2)
· ~1.5 hr



Map B: USGS NAIP imagery. The red line is approximate. Yellow dashed = classic glacier start. Glacier and snow extent vary by year.

- From the tarn the whole face is in view to the SW. The **Middle Palisade Glacier has two lobes** (north and south) separated by a rocky **medial moraine** that runs straight into the base of the face. **That moraine is your highway.**
- Head **SSW** over boulders and slabs to gain the broad moraine, then **stay on its crest** (cairns) as it curves SW toward the face. Expect loose, shifting blocks: test before you weight them.
- Your target is the **head of the moraine (M, ~12,700 ft)**, where it meets the rock. The **band of red/orange and white rock** just right (north) of it is your landmark.
- **October:** both lobes are usually **bare, hard ice** with rocks frozen in and a moat/bergschrund along the top. Don't walk on the ice without crampons. Stay on the moraine.
- Put on helmets here. Stash trekking poles and anything you don't need on the climb.

7. Getting onto the face



3D view of the East Face rendered from USGS lidar + NAIP imagery (not a photo), looking SW from just above the moraine. Red = red-rock start + main chute. Yellow dashed = classic glacier start. All lines approximate.

Option A: Red-rock start (recommended in October)

From the moraine head (M), go up and slightly **right (north)** into the gully/band of **red and white crumbly rock (R)**.

Climb it carefully: class 3 with a few **3+** moves, and **very loose**. Climb **one at a time**, or stay close together so a dislodged rock can't pick up speed. Nobody below anyone else in the fall line.

The gully leads up and then **LEFT** onto more solid rock and a good ledge system that joins the **main chute** above a **gendarme** (rock tower), roughly 300-400 ft above the moraine (**G**, ~13,100 ft).

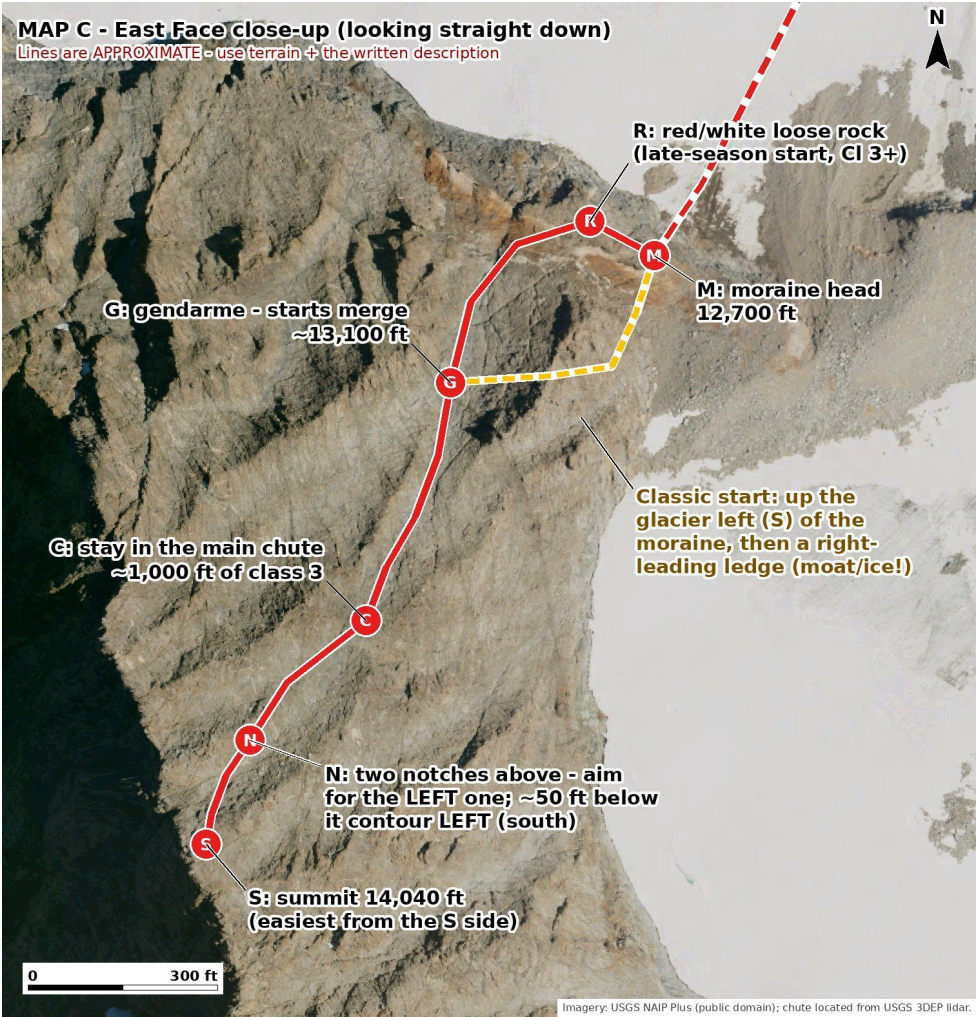
Beta: "the obvious red-rock alt route on the right side... steep, loose" (Sept 2020). "A gully of red and white crumbly rock, which then led up to the left to more solid rock and a good ledge system" (2018). The red chute was "not nearly as bad as it's made out to be" (Aug 2025). No snow or ice crossing is needed.

Option B: Classic glacier start (only with crampons + axe and a safe moat)

Climb the **left-hand (south) lobe** of the glacier, staying just left of where the moraine meets the face. About **50-80 ft left** of the moraine split, a **right-leading ledge/ramp** (class 3) goes up and right into the main chute.

Late season, the moat between ice and rock can be 10+ ft deep. Parties have kicked steps into vertical ice to cross it, or found a "quick 4th-5th class move about 15 feet above the glacier" (Sept 2013). If it looks bad, go back to Option A.

Don't improvise onto the face elsewhere. One party without crampons ended up on a class 4 chimney (2002). In Oct 2019, ~80% of the parties out that day turned back at the route-finding crux.



Map C: straight-down view of the face (USGS NAIP imagery; chute located with USGS lidar). Lines approximate.

8. The main chute to the summit

G to S · ~1,000 ft of sustained class 3 · 2-3 hr up

- **Once you're in the main chute, stay in it.** It's a broad chute (30-60 ft wide) of mostly solid, blocky granite with good holds, ledges and short steep steps that take a mantle or two. It is looser low down and cleaner higher up. "Ladder-like" on descent, one party said.
- About **a third of the way up**, another chute (the one Secor describes) **merges from the right**. Ignore it and keep climbing straight up the main line.
- When unsure, **trend LEFT**. Reports: "keep left"; "stay to the left of the towers"; "the further left you went up the gully, the rock got steeper and cleaner."
- **Rule of thumb:** if a move feels like class 4-5, you're probably off route. Back up and look left before committing.
- Look back down at the gendarme junction and other key spots on the way up. Take phone photos: you will need to recognize them on the descent.

The top: the part people get wrong

Near the top the chute narrows and **two notches** come into view above you. **Aim for the LEFT notch:** the summit is just left of it.

Don't climb all the way into the notch. About **50 ft below it**, start **contouring LEFT (south)** across a broken face to the base of the summit blocks.

The summit block is **class 5 direct**. The easier way **wraps around from the south side** and finishes on big class 3 blocks. The last few moves are awkward and exposed. Take the easiest line, not the most direct one.

If you top out on the crest **north** of the summit block, traverse south **below the crest on the east side**. One party reported a ~10 ft class 4 move there.

The summit is a narrow, airy perch with a register. Views: Split Mountain to the south; Norman Clyde, Mt. Sill and North Palisade to the north; Kings Canyon to the west.



Zoom of the 2020 photo: the East Face above the Middle Palisade Glacier from the northeast. The reddish rock at the base of the face is most likely the red-rock band beside the moraine head. Taken in June, with much more snow than October. Penitentes / Hike395, CC BY-SA 4.0.

9. Descent

- **Reverse the route exactly.** Downclimbing class 3 is slower than climbing it. Budget 2–3 hr from the summit to the moraine.
- Before leaving the summit, find the traverse you came in on and head back **north** below the crest to the top of the main chute.
- Face in on steep steps. Keep three points of contact. Test holds again: rocks you stood on can shift.
- **Stay in the main chute.** Don't get lured into side gullies. One party tried a side chute near the gendarme and found it "loose and crappy". They moved to the **north side of the main chute**, where the rock was more solid.
- At the **gendarme (G)**, take the start you came up. For the red-rock start, go down and right (north, facing out) via the ledges into the loose red/white gully, then to the moraine head. Go one at a time in the red rock.
- **Rockfall:** never descend directly above or below another party. Shout "ROCK!" for anything you knock loose.
- From the moraine head, **retrace the moraine crest** to the tarn. Don't shortcut toward Finger Lake down the glacier runoff. One party who did that hit "miles" of steep boulder fields.
- Tarn to the west side of Finger Lake to the outlet to the use trail down the W slope to Brainerd. Turn headlamps on **before** you need them. A 2012 party ran out of light and had to bivy 500 ft above Finger Lake.
- From Brainerd it is 4.3 mi of easy trail to the car. Watch your footing on the switchbacks when you are tired.

Descent landmarks to memorize on the way up

1. Where you left the summit traverse and entered the chute (look back from just below it).
2. The merge with Secor's chute (it enters from climber's right on the way up; don't follow it down).
3. The gendarme junction (G) where the red-rock and glacier starts split.
4. The red rock band and the moraine head (M): your exit to easy ground.

10. Gear checklist

Must have

- **Helmet:** rockfall is the #1 hazard on this route
- Approach shoes or stiff hiking shoes with sticky rubber
- **Headlamp + spare batteries** (you'll start and probably finish in the dark)
- Insulated jacket, wind/rain shell, warm hat, thin scrambling gloves + warm gloves
- 2-3 L water capacity + filter or tablets
- Food for 12-16 hr
- This PDF + GPX on a charged phone, battery pack, compass
- Satellite messenger or PLB (cell coverage is unreliable)
- First-aid kit, emergency bivy/space blanket, whistle
- Sunglasses, sunscreen, lip balm (high altitude, ice/snow glare)

Optional / conditional

- **Crampons + ice axe:** only for the classic glacier start (Option B)
- Microspikes: light insurance for frozen snow patches on the moraine in the morning
- Trekking poles for the trail and talus (stash them at the base of the face)
- Rope and a small rack are not needed on the standard route; bring them only if your party knows how to use them on alpine terrain
- Lightweight harness/belay device if you carry a rope

Clothing for tomorrow

Trailhead start ~5 AM: ~50°F. Finger Lake at 7-8 AM: near 40°F. Summit midday: mid-40s °F with 10-20 mph gusts, so it feels like the 30s. The face goes into shade in the afternoon, so the descent will be colder than the climb. Gloves you can scramble in are worth having.

11. Hazards, bail-out & emergency

- **Rockfall** (from other parties and your own). The chute funnels rocks. Climb close together or one at a time; never stand in the fall line below others. One reported party member was hit on the helmet by a baseball-sized rock.
- **Exposure:** ~1,300 ft of sustained class 3. A fall here would likely be fatal. Be honest about comfort levels in your party.
- **Loose rock**, especially in the red-rock start. Test every hold.
- **Ice/verglas:** October nights freeze. Shaded nooks can hold ice, and snow from any recent storm lingers on ledges. Turn back if the chute is iced.
- **Glacier & moat:** hard ice and a crevasse-like gap. Stay off unless equipped and experienced.
- **Darkness:** sunset 6:34 PM. The cross-country terrain above Brainerd is hard to follow at night. Use the GPX.
- **Altitude:** 14,000 ft. Headache, nausea or unusual fatigue are reasons to descend.
- **Weather:** the forecast is sunny. If clouds build fast or wind picks up sharply, retreat.

Turnaround rules

1:00 PM, no matter where you are.
Not at the base of the face (M) by ~10:30 AM? Seriously consider making it a scenic day.
Any doubt about the route above you? Back up to the last place you were sure, look left, and re-read section 8.

Emergency contacts

Emergency	911. Coverage is spotty: try high points, the summit, or near Brainerd. Use satellite SOS if you have it.
Inyo County Sheriff (SAR)	Non-emergency (760) 878-0383 · 550 S. Clay St., Independence
Nearest ER	Northern Inyo Hospital, 150 Pioneer Lane, Bishop · (760) 873-5811 (24/7 ER), ~25 mi from Big Pine
Forest Service	White Mountain Ranger Station, Bishop (760) 873-2500 · Wilderness permits (760) 873-2483
Your coordinates	Read them off your phone/GPS. Summit is ~37.0706, -118.4694. Moraine head ~37.0731, -118.4670.

12. Photo gallery



The East Face and Middle Palisade Glacier from the northeast on the approach from Finger Lake (June 2020). Penitentes / Hike395, CC BY-SA 4.0.



"The Thumb, centered, Birch Mountain behind. Middle Palisade Glacier below." A view east across the glacier basin you approach through. Jonathan Fox, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons.



The Palisades from the west (Observation Peak): North Palisade left, Middle Palisade right. Useful for naming peaks from the summit. David Bakken, CC BY-SA 2.5, via Wikimedia Commons.



The west side of Norman Clyde Peak, Middle Palisade and Disappointment Peak. This is what drops away beneath you on the far side of the summit. David Bakken, CC BY-SA 2.5, via Wikimedia Commons.

13. Sources & credits

Route information (trip reports and guides)

- Stav is Lost: "Middle Palisade via South Fork Big Pine Creek" (Aug 2025) · stavislost.com
- TrailnameBackstroke: "Ascent of Middle Palisade, September 2020" · trailnamebackstroke.com
- Quincy Koetz: "Middle Palisade Climb, October 2019" · quincykoetz.com
- SuperTopo trip report "Middle Palisade 9/11/13" (J. Lecorps) · supertopo.com
- Peaks for Freaks: "Middle Palisade" (June 2012) · peaksforfreaks.blogspot.com
- Tales from the Trail: "Middle Palisade NE Face via Brainerd Lake" (July 2018)
- The Mountains Are Calling: "Middle Palisade" · themtsarecalling.com
- Bob Burd trip report, Aug 22, 2002 · snwburd.com
- Climber.org trip reports: M. Bigelow "A Tale of Two Palisades" (2003); Middle Palisade (2002)
- Mountain Project forum: "East Face of Middle Palisade"
- Bryan Feller: "Five Guys on Middle Palisade" · David Stillman blog (2010) · Piero Scaruffi
- Wikipedia: Middle Palisade (first ascent F. Farquhar & A. Hall, Aug 26, 1921, by the East Face)
- R.J. Secor, The High Sierra: Peaks, Passes, and Trails (referenced by several reports)

Data

- Weather: National Weather Service API (api.weather.gov), forecasts issued 2026-10-02.
- Topographic base map, aerial imagery (NAIP Plus, 2025 service) and 1 m lidar elevation (3DEP): USGS The National Map. Public domain.
- Trails, lakes, trailhead and parking: © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL).
- Permits/contacts: Inyo National Forest; Inyo County Sheriff; Northern Inyo Healthcare District websites.
- Sunrise/sunset: computed for 37.10°N, 118.45°W (NOAA algorithm).

Photos (Wikimedia Commons)

- Middle Palisade on 2020-06-18: Penitentes (photo), Hike395 (conversion). CC BY-SA 4.0.
- The Thumb, Middle Palisade area: Jonathan Fox. CC BY-SA 2.0.
- Palisades of Sierra Nevada; Middle Palisades: David Bakken. CC BY-SA 2.5.
- Sierra Nevada from Hwy 168: Tom Hilton. CC BY 2.0.

All maps, 3D renders and diagrams in this guide were made for it from the public data above. 3D views are computer renderings, not photographs. Route lines off the maintained trail are approximate. Conditions change; glaciers and loose rock change year to year. Use your own judgment on the mountain.